BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) won nine out of Jharkhand's 14 Lok Sabha (LS) seats in the recent general election, it lost all the five LS seats reserved for the Scheduled Tribes (ST) in the state, bringing its tally down by three from the 12 it had won in the previous election in 2019. The JMM won three of these tribal seats and ally Congress the remaining two. Political observers interpreted the NDA's defeat in these seats as a sign of tribal resentment against the BJP over Hemant's arrest. That state of affairs is unlikely to be cured in the brief span left for the state election.

Meanwhile, Hemant, who couldn't campaign for his party and allies ahead of the Lok Sabha polls, has thrown himself body and soul into drumming up support for the upcoming state election. Political observers note a heightened sense of urgency in his actions and rhetoric. Speaking at Bhognadih village in Sahibganj district, some 375 kilometres northeast of Ranchi, on June 30, the JMM leader claimed, "I've barely tasted freedom again, and already there's a new conspiracy against me. Truth cannot be silenced, nor can it be chained." Describing his imprisonment as part of a broader pattern of suppression of political dissent and social activism, Hemant invoked the spirit of "*Hul Vidroh*" (*Hul* in Santhali means struggle for deliverance, *vidroh* is Hindi for rebellion) against what he termed entrenched "feudal forces". Bhognadih, located within his assembly segment of Barhait, is the birthplace of Sidhu and Kanhu, leaders of the 1855 Santhal Rebellion against the British. In his first public address after his release, Hemant positioned himself as a champion of tribal rights and a victim of political conspiracy, aiming to galvanise his support base in the state. On social media platform X, Hemant prominently displays a photo of himself alongside a statue of iconic tribal leader Birsa Munda, underlined with a single-word message: "Ulgulan" (great tumult)—a phrase synonymous with Munda's historic revolt against British rule over a century ago.

Tribals comprise 26 per cent of Jharkhand's population, according to the 2011 Census, with 28 of the state's 81 assembly seats reserved for STs. In the 2019 assembly polls, the BJP, then led by the state's only non-tribal chief minister Raghubar Das, had managed to secure only two of these seats, while the JMM-Congress-RJD alliance had clinched 25. Following its dismal performance in the ST reserved seats in the Lok Sabha election, the BJP has appointed party stalwart Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma as election incharges for the upcoming Jharkhand assembly polls. The defeat of former chief minister Arjun Munda from Khunti in the general election may also benefit the BJP in a way, allowing him to focus on reviving the party's waning tribal support in Jharkhand. However, his complex relationship with current state BJP president Babulal Marandi may put a spanner in the works.

Hemant has asked party workers to put the "last nail in the BJP's coffin" and is hoping to return to power in the coming election. Now to see if the electorate obliges. ■

Hemant Soren is positioning himself as a champion of tribal rights and a victim of political conspiracy

HARYANA

BIPOLAR FIGHT

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Politics in Haryana has bordered on the bizarre this year. On March 12 came the inexplicable resignation of Manohar Lal Khattar, sans any warning, his exit as much of a surprise as his installation as chief minister in 2014. Soon after came the BJP's parting of ways with the Dushyant Chautala-led JJP (Jannayak Janta Party), ostensibly over seat-sharing for the Lok Sabha polls. Then, in May, three Independent MLAs withdrew support to the new Nayab Singh Saini government, leaving it hanging by a tenuous majority. The Lok Sabha result gave no clear indication either, with the state's 10 seats evenly split between the Congress and the BJP.

As Haryana now braces for a state election, each side is busy honing strategy to stake a claim on the 90-seat assembly. There is, of course, the weight of history—the state has never given any party more than two continuous terms. If the Bhupinder Singh Hooda-led Congress held the reins from 2004 to 2014, the Modi wave in 2014 swept the BJP to power for the next decade. This time, the BJP is battling both anti-incumbency and a resurgent Hooda and is having to go the extra mile in its bid to defy history.

Replacing Khattar was the first in the BJP's attempt at course correction, since he was the one seen to be the cause of Jat disaffection, first over quotas, then over farm laws, and finally over the dishonour its women wrestlers were subjected to. And also of its aggravation, with his ultra-combative pushback against agitations overshadowing all the good

With his OBC credentials, Saini is expected to shore up the BJP's non-Jat OBC support to make up for the losses in the Jat vote